

IMAGES IN CLINICAL MEDICINE

Erythema Infectiosum



Jared Martinez-Coronado, M.D.¹
 Ramiro Salazar, M.D.¹
¹Universidad Autónoma de Coahuila,
 Saltillo, Mexico.

Ramiro Salazar can be contacted
 at ramirosmtz@outlook.com.

A PREVIOUSLY HEALTHY 8-YEAR-OLD BOY WAS BROUGHT TO THE DERMATOLOGY clinic with a 7-day history of an itchy rash on his cheeks and a lacy rash on his chest and arms. He reported no recent fever, runny nose, or malaise. On physical examination, there was a malar rash on both cheeks that spared the perioral region (Panel A) and a reticular rash on the trunk and arms (Panel B). A complete blood count was normal. A diagnosis of erythema infectiosum — also known as fifth disease — was made. Erythema infectiosum is a viral exanthem caused by parvovirus B19. It may involve a viral prodrome before the onset of the rash. After the viremia resolves, the rash appears as a “slapped cheek” pattern on the face and progresses to a lacy rash on the trunk. The rash may recrudesce in response to certain triggers — such as sunlight — after it resolves. Although the diagnosis of erythema infectiosum can be made clinically, serologic testing may be helpful for diagnosis in some cases. Reassurance was provided about the self-limited nature of the illness, and supportive care was recommended. At a 1-week follow-up visit, the rash had abated.

DOI: 10.1056/NEJMicm2509906

Copyright © 2025 Massachusetts Medical Society.